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Original Page: 6**Culture (OWC):** [Mbuti \(FO04\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Central Africa**Field Date:** 1970-1973 (P. Viii)**Coverage Date:** 1970-1973**Place Coverage:** Not Specified**Section Title(S):** Introduction

Then, in Part One, the scene is portrayed as it was in the colonial era, during which time the two populations, hunter-gatherer and farmer-fisher, again had to adapt to a totally new context, modifying the relationship between themselves accordingly. The colonial era ended with independence and the subsequent guerrilla warfare that raged throughout the Ituri for many years, two eyewitness accounts of which are given at the beginning of Part Two, one by a farmer and one by a hunter. Both populations were equally threatened by those years of war, but each emerged in some ways stronger and more unified than before. The years of war had compelled them to come to know each other in a way that had not previously been possible or necessary. But the years of war also created new lines of fission.

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I describe what changes I found in 1970, when I returned with a colleague to the Ituri following the years of war. Here we see the process of change continuing, but with an uncertain sense of direction. During this period the now-independent government attempted to induce major reforms and to persuade the hunters to abandon their former way of life, pursued for so many thousands of years with little interference, in order to become sedentary farmers. We still do not know the outcome of this situation, similar to situations faced in many developing nations where segments of the population are barely even aware that the nation exists. But a brief examination of this attempt to accelerate the pace of change for the national good does provide an opportunity to consider what role the anthropologist in the field can or should play.

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It is a rare privilege for an anthropologist to be able to return to the field so many times, although it is often disquieting to see some of the changes that have taken place among a people who seem so much at the mercy of the outside world. My own feelings in this respect have changed. But one thing

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that has not changed is my deep affection for the Mbuti, and although I am constrained by a joking relationship to say nasty things about them occasionally, for the neighboring African village farmers. That affection is mingled with immense respect for the way in which, during those thirty years, they have responded to changes that have taken place all around them, mostly imposed by external forces, without losing their immense zest for life, and without losing their essential humanity, their sense of what is right, meet, and proper, for themselves and for others.

And perhaps this is the place to say, without equivocation, that my affection extends equally and inextricably to the forest itself, for the forest and the people belong together in every respect, even in the eyes of "others." The forest was my first clue to the nature of the people who lived in it. It seemed limitless and totally apart from the rest of the world. Hundreds of miles across in any direction, it seemed almost as vast when one looked upward from the ground, since only in a very few places can the sky be seen through the canopy, which may be more than a hundred feet thick and does not even begin until about fifty feet above the ground. Unlike the world all around it, even at its very edge the forest is cool and shady, in places almost womb-like it seems so protective and all-embracing. It is certainly all-providing to those who know it, offering an abundance of all the necessities of life, and both physical and political security as well. Its very sounds, to the Mbuti, are constant reminders of what they take to be its protective, unquestionably

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